University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,391: Consultancy Project: EU External Relations

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (20%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Group work group grade (65%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Oral examination and technical discussions, Analog, Individual work individual grade (15%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,391,1.00 Consultancy Project: EU External Relations -- English -- Lehmkuhl Dirk , Albani Martin

Course information

Prerequisites

The basic prerequisite is an intrinsic interest in international affairs, its actors, principles and dynamics. As the course will focus on a specific conflict case (Yemen and the Red Sea) as well as the role of a specific actor (European Union), a basic understanding of either the case or the EU is helpful, but not mandatory.

Some introductory readings:

- https://www.crisisgroup.org/global/watch-list-2025-autumn-update
- https://www.cfr.org/global-conflict-tracker/conflict/war-yemen
- https://acleddata.com/monitor/yemen-conflict-monitor

Learning objectives

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

1. Comprehensively delineate the substance and context of the conflict case, its actors, its dynamics, its regional and international embeddedness.
2. Critically assess the European Union's crisis response and peacebuilding interventions, evaluating its understanding of the conflict, the effectiveness of its strategies, and the tools at its disposal.
3. Compellingly integrate their analysis into a real-life policy brief that derives coherent policy recommendations and action steps to be used by actual decision makers.
4. Constructively engage in a joint learning journey for all participants of the course.

Content

The European Union is becoming an increasingly influential actor in international affairs, engaging through a wide spectrum of instruments that range from humanitarian and development assistance to civilian and military crisis response missions, diplomacy, and mediation efforts. With its integrated approach to crisis response the EU aims to combine political, security, economic, and humanitarian tools in a coordinated manner to address conflicts in its neighbourhood and beyond. As one of the world’s largest providers of development and humanitarian assistance, equipped with a dedicated diplomatic service and an expanding security and defence posture, the EU plays an increasingly significant role in addressing global conflicts.

This student consultancy project focuses on a particularly urgent case of EU external action: the conflict in Yemen and the wider Red Sea crisis. One of the world's most protracted and devastating conflicts, Yemen is marked by a fractured state, competing authorities, and a humanitarian emergency affecting millions. Since late 2023, the situation has become increasingly entangled with broader regional dynamics: Houthi attacks on shipping in the Red Sea—framed as solidarity with Gaza—have further internationalised the crisis and drawn in Israel, the United States and the European Union, the latter having deployed a naval mission to safeguard trading routes in the highly geostrategic Red Sea region.

Co-led by a HSG professor specialized on European politics and an experienced EU diplomat, the course combines academic analysis with hands-on practitioner insights to provide a comprehensive understanding of how the EU engages in complex crises. Students will examine the evolution of the conflict, the EU's current involvement, the tools at its disposal, and the constraints and opportunities shaping European engagement in Yemen and the Red Sea crisis.

Throughout the project, students will develop concrete, actionable recommendations on how the EU could strengthen its response to the Yemen and Red Sea crisis. Working in teams, they will craft strategic proposals grounded in both policy realities and academic evidence, culminating in a presentation and discussion with EU officials and practitioners directly involved in the region and a written policy brief.

By participating in this course, students will gain a deeper understanding of EU external relations, crisis diplomacy, and integrated approaches to conflict management. They will also acquire practical experience in policy advising for real-world decision-makers confronting one of today's most pressing humanitarian, political and security crises.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course has four elements:

- An initial kick-off meeting that introduces the topic and sets the scenes in both conceptual and empirical terms, and also clarifies organisational issues.
- One interim 1:1 check-in meeting (online) between working groups and lecturers to discuss progress and open questions.
- Three block-seminar days with presentations, peer feedback, discussions and external guest(s).
- Policy brief to be handed in five weeks after the block seminar.

Student attendance is expected for all meetings.

I. Kick-Off: In Calender Week 9/2026

II. Interim: 1:1 check-ins between working groups and lecturers in Calender Week 11/2026 (online)

III. Main Seminar: During break

For the exact times, please check the course directory!

Assignments:

- A group presentation with a two-page factsheet on interim results (to be presented at the first day of the block seminar (technical details/requirements will be provided in class and on Canvas).
- Feedback and discussion of other groups interim results.
- A Policy brief that analytically-guided and empirically-informed analyses the EU's potential crisis response strategies and capacities and formulates policy recommendations accordingly (technical details/requirements will be provided in class and on Canvas).

Literature

A list of sources including literature and sources will be provided on Canvas at the beginning of the course.

Additional information

Martin Albani is an experienced diplomat at the foreign service of the European Union (European External Action Service - EEAS), currently on sabbatical. He is specialized on peacebuilding and conflict resolution, having served most recently as Head of the Peace Mediation and Dialogue Sector in the EEAS. He has worked in particular on conflicts in Sub-Saharan Africa and the wider Middle East, including Yemen. In addition to his diplomatic career, he teaches on peacebuilding and international negotiations at the universities of St.Gallen and Oxford.

Dirk Lehmkuhl has a Chair of European Politics at the HSG. He is co-ordirector of the Center for Governance and Culture in Europe (GCE-HSG) and was as Principal Investigator or collaborator involved in numerous research projects on the European Union.

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	20%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Group presentation plus 2-pager on interim result

Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade

Weighting	65%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Policy brief

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Oral examination and technical discussions
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	15%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Feedback and discussion of groups interims

Examination-aid rule
Open Book

Students are free to choose aids, apart from the following restrictions:

- pocket calculator models which are not part of the Texas Instruments TI-30 series, as well as any programmable electronic devices that are capable of communication such as electronic dictionaries, notebooks, tablets, smartphones, headsets, additional screens, etc. are not admissible;
- there is an option for faculty members to explicitly define exceptions under supplementary aids.

Procuring any aids, as well as ensuring their working order, is the exclusive responsibility of students.

Supplementary aids

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Content

- **Presentation**: A group presentation with a two-page factsheet on interim results (to be presented at the first day of the block seminar (technical details/requirements will be provided in class and on Canvas).
- **Feedback**: Individiual feedback and discussion of other groups interim results.
- **Paper**: A Policy brief that analytically-guided and empirically-informed analyses the EU's potential crisis response strategies and capacities and formulates policy recommendations accordingly (technical details/requirements will be provided in class and on Canvas).

Literature

A list of sources including literature and sources will be provided on Canvas at the beginning of the course.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).